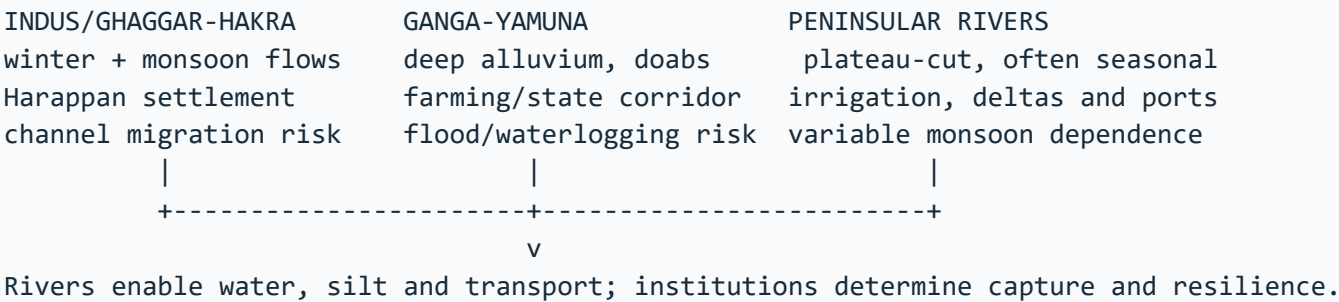


ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: Subcontinent as connected ecological regions

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      HIMALAYA / NORTH-WEST PASSES
    Kabul-Indus corridors | snowmelt rivers | frontier exchange
          v
INDUS BASIN ---- THAR/ARAVALLI ---- GANGA PLAIN ---- BRAHMAPUTRA VALLEY
floodplains      copper/route      alluvium/rice      rain/river routes
          |
      VINDHYAS / CENTRAL BELT
          |
DECCAN PLATEAU ---- EASTERN/WESTERN GHATS ---- COASTS AND DELTAS
black soils/metals passes and rain shadow      ports, rice, maritime links
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: River systems as opportunity and hazard



ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Monsoon-ecology-production loop

SEASONAL MONSOON



Surplus and settlement depend on storage, water control, labour and risk-sharing.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Resource geography and specialised regions

RESOURCE -> REPRESENTATIVE ZONES -> HISTORICAL CAPACITY

copper -> Aravalli/Khetri -> tools, exchange, craft centres

iron -> central/eastern India -> tools and weapons; use remains contextual

stone -> Rohri/Deccan/Vindhya -> lithics, architecture and sculpture

timber -> forest belts -> fuel, construction, boats, state frontier

salt -> arid/coastal sources -> essential exchange networks

elephant -> eastern forests -> military resource, not sole cause of empire

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Why settlements occupy particular landscapes

SITE SELECTION

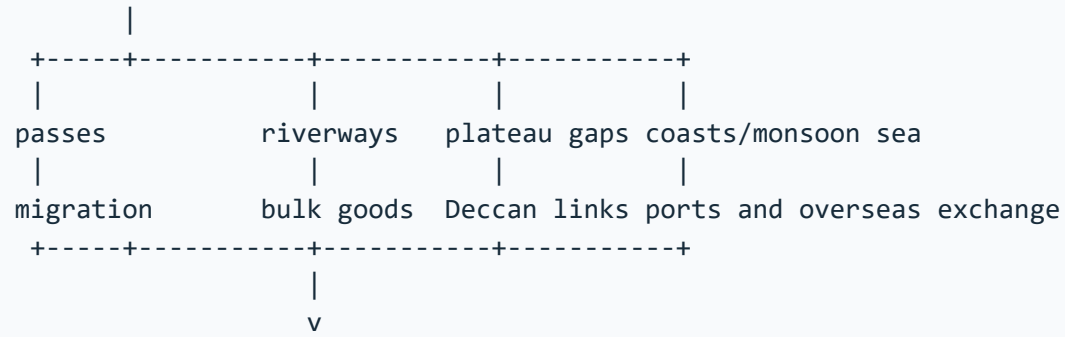
- |-- water reliability
- |-- cultivable soil and grazing
- |-- defensibility and flood safety
- |-- raw-material access
- |-- route, ford or port position
- |-- disease and drainage constraints
- |

+-> SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY: camp -> village -> craft centre -> town -> capital

Geography sets costs and options; social organisation converts them into settlement.

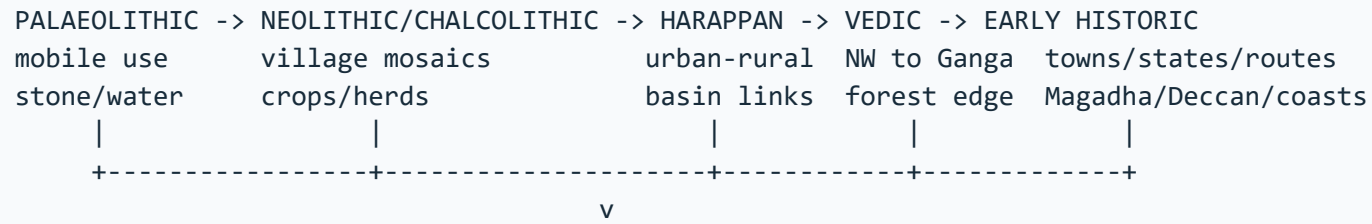
ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Routes: movement creates historical corridors

LAND AND WATER ROUTES



Goods, people, scripts, cults and technologies move; routes do not erase local agency.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Changing historical landscapes



No all-India stage occurs simultaneously: regional sequences overlap and diverge.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Determinism versus possibilism

DETERMINIST CLAIM: fertile soil, iron, river or monsoon automatically produces a state.

EVIDENCE AGAINST: similar environments yield different timings and institutions.

POSSIBILIST CORRECTION: ecology offers constraints, opportunities and recurring risks.

MEDIATORS: technology + labour + property + exchange + political organisation + culture

|

v

VERDICT: explain why an opportunity was mobilised, by whom, and with what limits.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Historical-geography answer architecture

10 MARKS: locate region -> name resource/ecology -> mechanism -> named case

15 MARKS: text map -> opportunities + constraints -> institutional mediators -> variation

20 MARKS: physical frame -> river/monsoon/resource systems -> chronological cases

-> routes and uneven regions -> determinism debate -> qualified synthesis

MAP RULE: label only places used in the argument; link each label to one consequence.

CLOSE: geography conditions history, but institutions select and transform options.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Evidence ladder and confidence control

EVIDENCE LADDER

1. = from source book = inference / standard knowledge = current affairs.
2. Claim Named evidence Significance Limitation
3. # Claim Named evidence Significance Limitation

VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Examiner traps and contested boundaries

CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

1. A-08 Climate proxies inform but do not settle Harappan transformation...
2. Contested issues Competing interpretations are attributed, evidenced...
3. Inscription and coin evidence: contemporary names, titles, claims and...

VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Integrated answer spine and qualified conclusion

ANSWER SPINE

1. Direct routed Mains ownership: 2023 GS-I Q1, geographical factors in...
2. Practice contract Every solved item has demand decoding, an examiner-...
3. UPSC RELEVANCE AND ANSWER-WORTHINESS AUDIT

VERDICT: Claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification lead to a graded...